

NO TIME TO QUIT

At 36, **Suchika Tariyal** is preparing for her Asian Games MMA debut, learning a new set of rules after nearly three decades in combat sports.

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A few weeks before her Asian Games debut in mixed martial arts, Suchika Tariyal is back to basics. On a mat above a restaurant in Mumbai's Andheri suburb, she splits her sessions between sparring and rules briefings from a referee who will officiate at the Aichi-Nagoya Games.

It's an unusual position for someone who has spent nearly three decades fighting. Tariyal has been a national-level judoka, reached a bronze medal bout at the Birmingham Commonwealth Games, represented India in Kurash at the Asian Games, and won a world title in Jiu-Jitsu. She has also had a brief run as a professional MMA fighter. Yet the rules of amateur MMA remain new to her.

"I was already fighting professionally but I saw a post on Instagram about trials for the Asian Games in Mumbai. I signed up without knowing the rules," she tells *Sportstar*. She won those trials, then travelled to China for the Asian Championships, where she reached the semifinals and a bronze medal before a defeat rooted less in ability than in unfamiliarity with the scoring system.

"I got her to the ground but was thinking like professional MMA, where you score for damage even

from the bottom. Amateur rules are different," she says.

At 36, Tariyal is relearning a sport at an age when most careers are ending. "I'm still competing. I'm still having fun. The most fun I'm having is in this," she says.

Where it started

While she can't imagine life without fighting, Suchika admits her entry into combat sports came by chance. It was a response to childhood trauma. The youngest of four daughters growing up in New Delhi, she recalls being sent to a neighbouring salon to get her hair cut when she was 10 years old.

"I hadn't learned anything about good touch or bad touch but I knew what was happening was wrong. I ran back home with my hair only half cut," she recalls.

The anger that followed, she says, turned into fights at school and a hostility towards boys, until her mother enrolled her in judo as an outlet. It quickly became more than that. Tariyal won her first national medal in 2011 and kept progressing through the age groups.

Progress off the mat was harder to come by, and harassment shadowed much of her career. At the Uttarakhand Police, she says she asked for time off to train and was instead met with inappropriate suggestions from seniors about how she could secure a promotion. "It was just harassment. I was under so

much mental trauma after that incident that I just left that job and returned to Delhi. It was always like this, where I wasn't ever encouraged to improve as much as I wanted," she says. She later took another government job, but the setbacks continued. In 2018, after qualifying for the Asian Games through trials, her weight category was dropped from the squad 10 days before departure. "I always wondered whether things would've been different with a supporter in the system," she says.

Her husband, Kapil Hooda, describes her as unwilling to defer to anyone for the sake of convenience. "She has this sense of pride in herself that she'll never do *ji huzuri* (be subservient). She's also stubborn. If she has a goal in her mind, she's going to keep chasing it. Not everyone likes that but that's who she is," he says.

She did represent India at the 2022 Commonwealth Games in judo's 57kg category, narrowly losing a bronze medal bout to two-time Olympian Christianne Legentil, but the buildup was clouded by infighting within the federation that saw the squad recalled from an international camp. It proved to be her last appearance for India in judo. "In India it isn't just about how good you are. So many other things decide whether you get to show your talent," she says of the federation politics and ministry visits that followed.